

American Linden (Basswood)

Tilia americana



Origin

Native to eastern and central North America, also called American basswood; historically an important tree for Indigenous communities, who used its fibrous inner bark for cordage and its soft wood for carving.

Look for

Its leaves are the largest of the linden species commonly planted in cities, often four to six inches long, with a lopsided heart-shaped base that's easy to feel with your fingers.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Leaf: large lopsided heart shape, four to six inches long -- the biggest of the city lindens.
- Flower: fragrant pale yellow clusters, heavy bee activity in early summer.
- Wood: historically prized by carvers for its soft, clean-carving grain.
- Commonly confused with: littleleaf linden (American linden's leaves are noticeably larger).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Large, uneven heart-shaped leaves unfold on a dense, pyramidal crown.
Summer	Fragrant pale yellow flower clusters draw heavy bee activity in early summer.
Fall	Leaves turn a soft yellow.
Winter	Distinct asymmetrical leaf-bud shape is visible on bare twigs.

DID YOU KNOW

- Its soft, light wood has long been favored by woodcarvers for detailed work because it carves cleanly along the grain.
- Basswood honey, made from its flowers, is prized by beekeepers for its light color and minty-floral taste.